We were best friends, maybe once lovers. When I took myself out of the army, he could not, and so condemned me to a life of exile. He swore that I would be visiting him at a mental institution, bringing home-baked biscuits. On my yearly visits to Israel I would hear his stories about Tibetan meditation and other spiritual quests in the Far East.

A while ago, this close friend in Israel became an extreme orthodox Jew, the friendship ended and I've lost him. In looking for ways to reconnect with him, or maybe make sense of his shift, I made a series of photographic stills of myself dressed as an orthodox Jewish man. These Black and White stills were the starting point of a visual and performative research into the appropriation of the frameworks of my own cultural heritage. Researching the stills involved following orthodox men in Jerusalem and discussing, with my father, the various dressing codes and their meanings. With time the right 'look' was created by 'diving under cover' into Stamford Hill, the orthodox Jewish neighbourhood in London. I did not want to follow a 'true' dressing code and hence associate myself with a particular sect within Jewish orthodoxy. I wanted people who are not familiar with the coded dressing to spot me as an orthodox Jew, but not one in particular, a signifier, an image, simulacra.

Following a number of photoshoot I found myself wanting to walk outside the door dressed up, I loved the way I felt, being dressed-up. As if something was 'corrected' inside me, home coming I guess. So was born my alter ego - Marcus Fisher. ' Mar-Cus' translated in Hebrew to 'Mr. Cunt'. The 'home coming ' feeling I associated with my relationship to Marcus is not particularly connected to my own sense of sexuality or a desire to be a man. It is culturally specific; it is my way to be visibly Jewish. It is my way into Judaism. If I am to enact potential Jewishness within me, it might as well be male Jewishness, that were the fun is and the privilige. It occurs to me that since my mother ran away from her orthodox family in Jerusalem, Marcus suggests a queer return to that family. It is a way to connect to this lost family whom I would be pushed to recognise, if met them face to face in the street. It is also a way to exercise my cultural identity in England. A place where Jewishness is yet to be recognized, (by Jewish people too), as an ethnic and racial origin, rather than as a

religion. It is an also a way to connect with patriarchy, Marcus is my way to connect with patriarchal orthodoxy as well as with the Jewish State, a country driven by macho Jews. Marcus is looking for his masculine identity, somewhere between the effeminate Eastern European orthodox Jew and the Israeli ultra masculine Jew.

After walking spontaneously to clubs and the streets, these spontaneous interventions gave way to selective ones documented on video from afar. The main three interventions were Soho, London - a haven of diversity where Marcus was testing the limits of multiculturalism and street- fashion. The second intervention was in a beach in Tel Aviv - Marcus went to a secular beach rather than the assigned orthodox beach and tested the limits of Otherness. The third intervention was in a men's only Turkish cafe in Berlin, where Marcus was welcomed with slight bemusement and tested the boundaries of masculinity and religion.

Marcus became an art project.

Marcus still haunts me, demanding to be seen, I tried to kill him in various ways, including a wake party, but it seems that he is here to stay. He is part me, he is the space where I question with others what is it to be or to relate to a Jew, here, now.

Later on I/Marcus begun to incorporate stage/club performances into the interventions. I became particularly interested in rituals; every-day ones like smoking, as well as religious Jewish rituals - due to the specific readings they impose on the body. After the period of interventions and performances I wanted Marcus to meet intimately with people, which is how the live interaction 'Say Cheese' came about.

In May 2003 Marcus danced with hundreds of orthodox Jewish men in the religious celebrations of 'Lag Baomer' at the north of Israel. For the first time I chose to go to a place where Marcus 'fits' in. The feeling was tremendous, the high I felt whilst dancing and being excepted by those men is indescribable, a true connection, belonging and sense of history and home. I seems could only feel truly connected by being a 'cheat', an impostor, queer, by not belonging at all. Following my 'outsider status'

throughout my youth in Israel, and as an immigrant through my adulthood in England, it seems that I can only feel belonging through the experience of not belonging, it is the only true feeling I know of home.

Since the bstart of the project to date; videos, photographs, text, performances, interactions, interventions have been shown widely in a variety of contexts. Marcus has an art career parallel and at the same time separate to mine.

Marcus does not have a real character or personality; he also does not stand for any political ideology, that would be deductive and reductionist. Marcus ‘works’ because he is a vacant simulacrum, a mirror that reflects the complexities of a Jewish Israeli identity in itself and in relation to others. The project attempts to create situations in which to experience the ‘relating’ to a Jew and all that this immplies. Marcus is a disturbance, a high-pitched note, made in order to flex socio-political and cultural realities.

It's coming back, in dreams, mood swings, and the daily press; a country that will not let go of me. They invited me to perform but got scared at the last minute, and I cannot quite recall if I saved the Palestinian boy, or actually murdered him last night. In any case my sleep here, in England is disturbed by the thumping of my own brain only, his are soldiers’ noises.

'...but its too late baby, now its too late, though we really did try to make it, something inside has died and I can't hide it , I just can't fake it, its too late baby, its too late, ho darling'.